

Prologue

"I guess we've got a few people you could talk to." The monotone voice reluctantly agreeing to help belonged to a rather bored-looking half-elf at the reception desk in the Mages' Guild headquarters on Bral. Kireh Helinwa had come searching for information on constructs—particularly of Clockwork design. While the receptionist hadn't initially been very... forthcoming—possibly due to her reputation—he'd finally been *convinced* to see things her way with a little prodding.

"Anyone local? Travel can get expensive, you know, and I get ornery if I have to cut my own budget for no good reason. If I end up wasting my time, I'd rather it be cheap." Kireh narrowed her eyes at the man and gave him a smirk. Truthfully, she didn't care at all—she was just enjoying messing with him after he'd been so unhelpful just moments before.

"Well, not locally, no. But you're in luck; we do have an expert visiting currently. She's trying to get her funding renewed after one of her coworkers... went a bit senile. Forgot to send in applications for a few years, ya know? She's in with Ward right now, but if you want to wait—"

Kireh did not. She immediately started walking towards the hall, manipulating the spatial magic integrated into the building to direct her to Ward's office. She understood how this building worked—she'd been around while they were building the tower, and had even pitched in a bit for free. Of course, what they hadn't known at the time was that she had installed a shortcut for herself to enable quick access to the leader's office. Sooner or later, they'd figure it out and remove it, but it was always fun to pop in unannounced to visit Ward whenever she needed something. Kireh chuckled to herself; she couldn't help but wonder if the latest receptionist had specifically been hired to keep her out—not that he had been successful, if that were the case.

As Kireh opened the door into the office, she could see the imposing figure of Ward sitting at his desk, clearly feeling superior, like he held all the power in his tiny little room, like he had his guest dancing in his palm for him. Well, he *did*, until Kireh walked into the room. If a warforged could lose the color in his face, he would have. His eyes widened in surprise as much as they could, and Kireh could swear that his posture shrank down a bit, hunched over like he'd lost his confidence.

"Ah. If it isn't the wonderful Kira Helinwa. Always a pleasure to see you. To what do we owe this very welcome intrusion?" Ward stood up from his chair, trying to regain a bit of his presence.

"It's *Kireh*, thank you very much." Kireh stared down Ward, daring him to meet her gaze.

"My apologies, *Ms. Helinwa*. What can I do for you?"

"Actually, *Mr. Ward*, I'm not here for you today. I merely heard you had a guest I may be interested in speaking to." With that, Kireh finally broke her stare to look over at the other person in the room. Sitting in a chair in front of Ward's desk was a gnomish woman, maybe three feet tall, with medium-length brown hair, a freckled face, and olive skin. Attached to her hip was a device that looked similar to a hand crossbow, but with a tubular barrel and no crossbar—clearly a weapon or tool of some kind, but not one Kireh had ever seen before. What really caught her eye, though, was the woman's eyes. They burned

with a calculating determination, like she was always in a bad spot but still figuring out the best path forward. *Huh. She's kind of cute.*

"You're here for me, ma'am?" The gnome's eyebrows raised quizzically, but despite looking *at* Kireh, she seemed to be looking just off to the side—not really meeting her eyes, but staring off into the distance nearby.

"Correct. I heard you may be an expert on constructs, and information on what I'm looking for seems to be *dreadfully* hard to come by in this so-called institute of magic." The guest's head tilted somewhat.

"I'd say I'm an expert, yeah. Spent many years working on constructs." The gnome's eyes lit up and a brief smirk crossed her face as an idea came to mind. Clearly grasping the shift in power dynamics since Kireh had arrived, the gnome turned to face Ward while still addressing Kireh. "In fact, I'd *love* to help you with your research, but you see, *someone* is trying to defund my research, and I dunno if I'll have the time, what with all the moving and selling and finding a job. It's gonna be *so* rough, and I don't think I can help, Ms. Kireh." Kireh broke into a grin; she knew she was being used, but she didn't mind *at all*. She always enjoyed bothering those in power, especially when they were jerks like the royalty back on Anglere, and besides—she *liked* this girl. She had guts *and* brains.

"You know, Ward, I think your guest is right. She really won't be able to help me... unless you renew her funding, of course. It'd be such a shame if I had access to such a useful resource right here and then lost it due to your incompetence. Best case scenario, I'd have to come back and bother the Mages' Guild over and over again for a replacement. Worst case scenario... *I might start to lose faith in your leadership.* And I have such a nasty habit of complaining loudly to all those government officials at all the parties I go to. 'Twould be a shame, wouldn't it?" Kireh smiled. It was all a bluff—each of the governments tried to keep her as far away as they could. She still had power, though. Much like how she could come visit the head of the Mages' Guild as she pleased, she also had ways of getting audiences with other high-ranking officials in various governments and organizations. If she chose, she could make Ward's life a living hell, and she would have many sweet dreams because of it.

Ward sighed. "I... suppose we can renew your funding for another year—IF you get the paperwork in. Don't miss the deadline next year, or we'll have to have another discussion. If that's all, please leave. I think I'm getting a headache, and I didn't know that was even possible. I'm going to have to go find *that* guy and see if he's got something that works on warforged..."

"I'm so happy to hear that, Ward. It's always such a pleasure to get to talk with you. Until next time!" Kireh turned towards the door, where she noticed the other guest had already made her way out and was heading down the hallway.

"Please don't come back." Ward's voice was muffled from behind his hands. Kireh smiled as she left the room.

Outside the Mages' Guild, Kireh found Ward's guest waiting for her.

"Ah, the expert! Way to play your cards back there; not everyone can react to drawing a new hand quite so quickly, or so well." Kireh smiled at her.

"No no no, not at all! I wanted to apologize for that; I feel awful about using you like that, Ms. Kireh. If there's any way I can help, to repay you, please let me!" The gnome's eyes finally aligned on Kireh's face, where she seemed to... flinch? Followed by a slight blush. It was an odd reaction, Kireh thought, but she seemed an odd woman already.

"Well, for starters, you can drop the 'Ms.' and just call me Kireh. Would probably also be nice to have something to call you other than 'the expert,' you know."

"Oh! That's, uh, sorry! I'm, uh, I'm sin—I mean, I'm Elyssa! Elyssa Asato, at your service!" Kireh giggled.

"You're cute, that's what you are. Come along, I know a bar where we can talk for a while—my treat." The gnome blushed at the compliment and followed as Kireh led them down the street.

"You said you were looking for an expert on constructs, right? Anything in particular you're trying to learn?" As they walked, the sounds of the crowd made it more difficult to hear Elyssa's voice.

"Yes. You see, I've always been interested in them. I've been curious about how they work, and what it would take to make them. And then a... well, a few years back, I had some interesting encounters with some Clockwork Horrors. Made me all the more curious about them. So I suppose I've got two different areas I'm interested in studying, really. Constructs as a whole, but then also the Clockwork Horrors in particular." Kireh looked around for anyone listening in before stopping and kneeling over next to the gnome. "Just between you and me, I think there's a bit more to the Horrors than people realize. I've heard some interesting stories, seen some interesting variations, and, well... it's fascinating. Concerning, but fascinating."

Elyssa's ears perked up at that as the two of them began to walk again. "Wait, you think there's more to them too?? I fought some one time, and they seemed *way* too complex for how simple people describe their behavioral patterns! Like, they seemed to have their own language, and could communicate locally through the Weave without verbal or physical communication methods! That alone is a level of complexity and overdesign that implies either deeper design fundamentals or potentially even a biological-akin evolutionary design! For all we know, the Horrors could be living creatures with countless eons of adaptations leading to them being how they are currently—that's how complex they *seemed* to me, and everyone just says I'm overthinking it! I'm not overthinking *anything*! If anything, everyone else is *underthinking* it, and it drives me crazy!" Kireh smiled at her companion's sudden burst of enthusiasm. Elyssa shrunk down a bit as she realized it.

"Gee, I'm sorry, Kira. I didn't mean to go off like that. It's just exciting to hear I'm not alone about all that." As the two of them stopped in front of The Laughing Beholder, Kireh looked over at her companion.

"There's no need to apologize." Kireh gave Elyssa a teasing smile. "Your enthusiasm is welcome, *E*. Come on. I think we'll have a *lot* to discuss."